

Shriram Subramanian, Founder and MD of InGovern Research Services, a proxy advisory firm. “Why should they [Ola] be transparent? Only when they come for listing, we should be worried because the level of disclosure and scrutiny that’s required for a public investor is a completely different ball game.”

Kejriwal also questions why money needs to be raised for an asset-light business (Ola Cabs) that is no longer burning cash: “Why can’t it run a business without asking [for] the kind of money it has asked [for]? The market is worried about it. There needs to be a segregation of the ownership of the two companies. Anybody new coming [in] will face the brunt. There will be more scrutiny for these start-up IPOs,” he says. Former employees *BT* spoke to also accused Aggarwal of pulling down Ola Cabs on purpose because his stake in the company is low.

To Aggarwal, however, the two businesses are clearly delineated. “The corporate structure is very simple. There are two companies. There’s Ola, which is the ride sharing and related consumer tech companies (financial services), Ola Dash (grocery delivery) and second hand used car business (Ola Cars). Ola Electric is the Ola S1 and we’re building a car, cells, etc. If investors are giving me money, they’re doing it after much thinking through,” he explains, adding that in its run-up to the IPO, Ola investors will be positively surprised. “We’re profitable. We crossed that path a year or two ago. That’s why we don’t need to perpetually keep raising funds. And for Ola Electric, when we come out with our financials, people will be surprised to see our capital efficiency. We would beat all incumbents hands down. Our profitability target will be early next year for the two-wheeler business,” he says.

THE WORK CULTURE

Ola’s businesses have seen at least 15 top-level exits in the past two years, including Dinesh Radhakrishnan, who handled engineering functions across both Ola Electric and Ola Cabs; Arun Sirdeshmukh, head of the used car business Ola Cars; Ola’s chief marketing officer Varun Dubey and CFO Swayam Saurabh; Ola Electric’s head of quality assurance Joseph Thomas; and Ola’s chief operating officer Gaurav Porwal. Many have highlighted the company’s tough work culture behind its constant churn of talent. Aggarwal counters that forcefully: “We’re the best actually in senior talent retention in the industry. Our culture is one of impact. We’re an ambitious company; we have an agenda and a mission. We want to change our industries, disrupt them; we want to help create new industries in India. That’s what drives us. There’s a cer-

THE UPSTART

Ola’s electric scooter sales are third-highest in this calendar year although it is No. 1 in FY23 so far

	Jan '22	Feb '22	Mar '22	Apr '22	May '22	Total
Okinawa	5,613	5,923	8,284	11,012	9,303	40,135
Hero Electric	7,763	7,356	13,023	6,572	2,850	37,564
Ola	1,102	3,904	9,121	12,691	9,225	36,043
Ampere	4,218	4,303	6,338	6,539	5,836	27,234
Ather Energy	1,880	2,229	2,222	2,445	3,323	12,099
PURE EV	1,690	1,427	2,066	1,756	1,466	8,405

FIGURES ARE NUMBER OF UNITS SOLD; LIST NOT COMPREHENSIVE

SOURCE: FADA

10
MILLION

THE ANNUAL CAPACITY
AT OLA’S ELECTRIC TWO-
WHEELER FACTORY AFTER
IT IS COMPLETE

9
MILLION

THE CURRENT CAPACITY
OF CONVENTIONAL TWO-
WHEELER MARKET LEADER
HERO MOTOCORP